

London Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
- **Language:** English (with diverse accents and dialects)
- **Currency:** British Pound Sterling (GBP, £)
- **Time Zone:** Greenwich Mean Time (GMT, UTC+0), BST in summer (UTC+1)
- **Emergency Number:** 999 (police, fire, ambulance), 112 also works
- **Dialing Code:** +44
- **Nickname:** The Big Smoke

Visa Requirements

Post-Brexit Entry Rules (Updated 2024)

Visa-Free Entry (Tourism)

6 Months Visa-Free: - **United States:** 6 months - **Canada:** 6 months - **Australia:** 6 months - **New Zealand:** 6 months - **Japan:** 6 months - **South Korea:** 6 months - **Singapore:** 6 months - **Malaysia:** 6 months

EU/EEA Citizens (Post-Brexit): - **Duration:** 6 months visa-free (changed from free movement) - **Note:** Can no longer work or study without visa (major change from pre-2021) - **Passport:** Valid passport required (ID cards no longer accepted)

Entry Requirements

- Valid passport (must be valid for duration of stay)
- Return or onward ticket
- Proof of sufficient funds (rarely checked, but £100/day recommended)
- Proof of accommodation
- No visa interview required for visa-free countries

Important Post-Brexit Notes

- EU citizens now treated as international visitors

- No automatic right to work, study, or live
- Separate immigration queues for UK/Irish vs all others
- Biometric passport gates available for eligible nationalities

ETA (Electronic Travel Authorization - Coming 2024-2025)

- Similar to US ESTA system
- Required for visa-free travelers (including EU)
- Cost: £10
- Apply online before travel
- Valid for multiple visits over 2 years
- **Check official UK government website for implementation date**

Longer Stays

- **Study Visa:** Required for courses over 6 months
- **Work Visa:** Required for any employment (Skilled Worker visa, etc.)
- **Ancestry Visa:** For Commonwealth citizens with UK-born grandparent (5 years)

Best Time to Visit

Spring (March - May)

- **Weather:** 8-15°C (46-59°F), mild, increasingly sunny
- **Highlights:** Gardens blooming (Kew Gardens, Hyde Park), longer days, spring festivals
- **Crowds:** Moderate, increasing in May
- **Events:** Chelsea Flower Show (May), Easter celebrations, Marathon (April)
- **Pros:** Pleasant weather, flowers, fewer crowds than summer, outdoor activities resume
- **Cons:** Unpredictable rain, still cool early spring, some chilly days

Summer (June - August)

- **Weather:** 18-25°C (64-77°F), warmest but rarely hot, occasional heatwaves
- **Highlights:** Outdoor events, festivals, long daylight (sunset ~9:30pm), terraces open
- **Crowds:** Very high (peak tourist season)
- **Events:** Wimbledon (June-July), Notting Hill Carnival (August), Hyde Park festivals
- **Pros:** Best weather, long days, vibrant atmosphere, outdoor events, terrace culture

- **Cons:** Crowded attractions, expensive accommodation, tube uncomfortably hot

Fall (September - November)

- **Weather:** 10-18°C (50-64°F), cooling, more rain
- **Highlights:** Autumn foliage (parks beautiful), cultural season begins, fewer tourists
- **Events:** London Fashion Week (September), Bonfire Night (November 5), Christmas markets start
- **Pros:** Comfortable temperatures, beautiful autumn colors, lower prices, museums less crowded
- **Cons:** Rain increases, days getting shorter, can be gray

Winter (December - February)

- **Weather:** 2-8°C (36-46°F), cold, damp, occasional snow
- **Highlights:** Christmas markets, festive lights, theater season, January sales
- **Events:** Christmas, New Year's Eve fireworks, Chinese New Year, Winter Wonderland (Hyde Park)
- **Pros:** Festive atmosphere (December), lowest prices (January-February), cozy pubs, no crowds
- **Cons:** Very short days (sunset ~4pm), cold and damp, gray skies, some attractions reduced hours

Recommended Visit: May-June (warm, long days, pre-peak prices) or September (post-summer, still nice weather).

Best Value: January-February (lowest prices, but cold and gray).

Avoid: August (most crowded, expensive, many locals on holiday).

Top Attractions

Attraction	Area	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit
Big Ben & Houses of Parliament	Westminster	Free (tours £28)	Exterior 24/7, tours vary	Early morning (fewer crowds), evening (lit up)
Tower of London	Tower Hill	£34.80	9:00-17:30 (summer)	Weekday morning, pre-book online
British Museum	Bloomsbury	Free (donations welcome)	10:00-17:00	Weekday morning, Friday late (to 20:30)
Buckingham Palace	Westminster	£33 (State Rooms, summer)	9:15-19:15 (Jul-Oct)	Morning, book ahead, Changing of Guard 11:00
Westminster Abbey	Westminster	£27	9:30-15:30 (Mon-Sat)	Early morning (less crowded), closed Sundays
London Eye	South Bank	£32-42	10:00-20:30	Sunset (book timed slot), weekdays
St. Paul's Cathedral	City of London	£23	8:30-16:30 (Mon-Sat)	Early morning, climb dome for views, closed Sundays for worship
Tate Modern	South Bank	Free (special exhibitions £18-22)	10:00-18:00	Weekday, Friday/Saturday late (to 22:00)
Natural History Museum	South Kensington	Free	10:00-17:50	Early weekday morning, avoid weekends/holidays
Borough Market	Southwark	Free (food costs)	10:00-17:00 (Wed-Sat)	Thursday-Friday lunch (full market, less crowded than Saturday)

Additional Must-See Attractions

- **Hyde Park/Kensington Gardens:** Royal parks, Serpentine lake, Diana Memorial (free)
- **Camden Market:** Alternative culture, food, vintage shopping (free, food/goods cost)
- **Covent Garden:** Street performers, boutique shops, Apple Market (free)
- **Sky Garden:** Free rooftop views from 20 Fenchurch St (book free tickets ahead)
- **Churchill War Rooms:** WWII underground bunker (£33)
- **Shakespeare's Globe:** Reconstruction of original theater (tours £17, shows £5-55)

- **The Shard:** Observation deck, tallest building in Western Europe (£32-40)

Areas and Neighborhoods

Westminster

- **Character:** Political heart, iconic landmarks, royal sites
- **Must-See:** Big Ben, Houses of Parliament, Westminster Abbey, Buckingham Palace, St. James's Park
- **Food:** Tourist restaurants (pricey), historic pubs, high tea at hotels
- **Transport:** Westminster, St. James's Park (Circle, District, Jubilee lines)
- **Best For:** First-time visitors, UK history, royalty, classic London landmarks

South Bank

- **Character:** Cultural hub along Thames, modern and artsy
- **Must-See:** London Eye, Tate Modern, Southbank Centre, Borough Market, Shakespeare's Globe
- **Food:** Borough Market (gourmet food stalls), riverside restaurants, street food
- **Transport:** Waterloo, Southwark, London Bridge (multiple lines)
- **Best For:** Culture, riverside walks, food markets, street performers, views

Shoreditch

- **Character:** Hipster central, street art, vintage shops, nightlife
- **Must-See:** Brick Lane (curry houses, vintage markets), street art, independent galleries, trendy cafes
- **Food:** Diverse cuisines, trendy brunch spots, food markets (Sunday UpMarket)
- **Transport:** Shoreditch High Street, Liverpool Street (Overground, Circle, Central lines)
- **Best For:** Young crowd, nightlife, street art, vintage shopping, alternative culture

Camden

- **Character:** Alternative culture, punk rock heritage, markets
- **Must-See:** Camden Market, Regent's Canal, music venues (Electric Ballroom, Roundhouse)
- **Food:** International street food at markets, rock/punk themed restaurants
- **Transport:** Camden Town (Northern line)
- **Best For:** Markets, alternative fashion, live music, canal walks, counterculture

Notting Hill

- **Character:** Affluent residential, pastel-colored houses, famous market
- **Must-See:** Portobello Road Market (Saturday antiques), colorful streets, boutique shops
- **Food:** Trendy cafes, upscale restaurants, market food stalls
- **Transport:** Notting Hill Gate, Ladbroke Grove (Central, Circle, Hammersmith & City lines)
- **Best For:** Instagram-worthy streets, antiques, upscale shopping, film location (Notting Hill movie)

Kensington & Chelsea

- **Character:** Posh residential, museums, upscale shopping
- **Must-See:** Natural History Museum, V&A Museum, Science Museum, Kensington Palace, Harrods
- **Food:** High-end restaurants, afternoon tea, luxury dining
- **Transport:** South Kensington, Knightsbridge (Piccadilly, District, Circle lines)
- **Best For:** Museums, luxury shopping, royal parks, upscale London

The City (Financial District)

- **Character:** Modern financial hub, historic City of London, contrasts old and new
- **Must-See:** St. Paul's Cathedral, Tower of London, Tower Bridge, Sky Garden, Leadenhall Market
- **Food:** Business lunch spots, historic pubs (Ye Olde Cheshire Cheese), fine dining
- **Transport:** Bank, Liverpool Street, Moorgate (multiple lines)
- **Best For:** Business district, historic sites, architecture, weekdays bustling (quiet weekends)

Food & Dining

Traditional British Food

Full English Breakfast

- **Description:** Eggs, bacon, sausages, baked beans, mushrooms, tomatoes, black pudding, toast
- **Price:** £8-15 at cafes, £15-25 at hotels
- **Where:** Terry's Cafe (traditional greasy spoon), The Wolseley (upscale), local pubs
- **Verdict:** Hearty, filling, perfect for cold mornings

Fish and Chips

- **Description:** Battered fish (usually cod or haddock), thick-cut chips, mushy peas, tartar sauce
- **Price:** £8-12 takeaway, £12-18 sit-down
- **Where:** Poppies (Spitalfields, traditional), The Golden Hind, local chippies
- **How to Order:** "Salt and vinegar?" (say yes for authentic experience)
- **Verdict:** Classic British, best from proper chippies not chains

Sunday Roast

- **Description:** Roasted meat (beef, lamb, chicken, or pork), roast potatoes, vegetables, Yorkshire pudding, gravy
- **Price:** £12-18 at pubs, £20-35 at restaurants
- **When:** Sundays 12:00-17:00 at most pubs
- **Where:** The Harwood Arms, The Guinea Grill, local pubs
- **Verdict:** Sunday institution, cozy pub atmosphere

Afternoon Tea

- **Description:** Finger sandwiches, scones with clotted cream and jam, pastries, tea
- **Price:** £25-40 standard, £50-75 luxury hotels (Ritz, Savoy)
- **When:** 15:00-17:00 typically
- **Dress Code:** Smart casual minimum, some require jackets
- **Where:** Sketch (Instagram-famous), The Ritz, Fortnum & Mason
- **Verdict:** Quintessentially British, special occasion experience

Pie and Mash

- **Description:** Meat pie, mashed potatoes, parsley liquor (eel sauce traditionally)
- **Price:** £6-10
- **Where:** M. Manze (oldest pie shop), Goddards at Greenwich
- **Verdict:** Working-class London tradition, authentic East End

Pub Culture (Essential London Experience!)

What are Pubs?

- Public houses - community gathering spots, not just for drinking
- Serve beer, cider, spirits, often food

- Age-old tradition, each pub has distinct character
- Central to British social life

Pub Etiquette

- **Ordering:** Go to bar to order (don't wait for table service in traditional pubs)
- **Rounds:** If in group, buy "rounds" (everyone takes turn buying for whole group)
- **Tipping:** Not required at bar, optional for table service (10%)
- **Standing:** Perfectly acceptable to stand with drink (not all pubs have seats)
- **Closing Time:** "Last orders" called 15 min before closing (usually 11pm weekdays, midnight weekends)
- **Conversation:** Pubs are for chatting, making friends, locals welcoming

Drinks to Try

- **Real Ale:** Traditional cask-conditioned beer (Fuller's London Pride, Timothy Taylor's)
- **Bitter:** Amber-colored beer, hoppy (classic pub drink)
- **Cider:** Apple cider, often stronger than you expect
- **Gin & Tonic:** London invented gin, try craft gins
- **Pimm's:** Summer drink, fruity and refreshing (Pimm's Cup)

International Cuisine

- **Indian:** Britain's favorite cuisine, Brick Lane famous for curry (£10-20)
- **Chinese:** Chinatown (Leicester Square), dim sum, Peking duck
- **Middle Eastern:** Shawarma, falafel, Turkish food (Edgware Road, Green Lanes)
- **Italian:** Pizza, pasta, gelato (everywhere)
- **Vietnamese:** Pho, banh mi (Kingsland Road)

Markets (Food Lover's Paradise)

- **Borough Market:** Gourmet food stalls, artisan producers (Wed-Sat, £8-15 meals)
- **Camden Market:** International street food (daily, £6-12 meals)
- **Portobello Road:** Antiques (Sat), plus food stalls
- **Broadway Market:** Hipster food stalls (Saturday, Hackney)

Tipping and Service

- **Restaurants:** 10-12.5% typical (sometimes included as "service charge")

- **Check Bill:** If service charge included, don't tip extra
- **Pubs:** No tipping at bar, optional for table service (£1-2 or round up)
- **Cafes:** Tip jars common, £0.50-1 optional
- **Taxis:** 10% or round up

Price Ranges

- **Budget (£8-15/meal):** Pub food, chain restaurants, street food, markets, takeaway
- **Mid-Range (£18-35/meal):** Casual restaurants, pub Sunday roast, afternoon tea
- **High-End (£50-100+/meal):** Fine dining, Michelin stars, luxury hotels

Transportation

From Airports

Heathrow Airport (LHR) - Main International Gateway

- **Location:** 24 km west of central London (30-75 minutes depending on method)
- **Elizabeth Line (Fastest, Recommended):** Direct to central London (Paddington, Bond St, Tottenham Court Rd, Liverpool St) - £12.80, 30-45 min
- **Piccadilly Line (Cheapest):** Tube to central London - £5.60 off-peak, 50-60 min
- **Heathrow Express:** Fast train to Paddington - £25-37, 15-20 min (expensive, not worth it vs Elizabeth Line)
- **National Express Coach:** Budget option to Victoria - £7-10, 40-75 min
- **Taxi (Black Cab):** £50-90 to central London, 45-90 min (traffic dependent)
- **Uber:** £40-70 depending on time

Gatwick Airport (LGW) - Budget Airlines

- **Location:** 45 km south of London (30-60 minutes)
- **Gatwick Express:** Train to Victoria - £19.90, 30 min
- **Southern/Thameslink:** Slower trains to Victoria/London Bridge - £11-14, 35-45 min
- **National Express:** Coach to Victoria - £9-12, 70-90 min
- **Taxi:** £70-100 to central London
- **Uber:** £60-90

Stansted Airport (STN) - Ryanair/EasyJet

- **Location:** 64 km northeast of London (45-60 minutes)
- **Stansted Express:** Train to Liverpool Street - £19.40, 47 min
- **National Express:** Coach to Victoria - £10-14, 75-100 min
- **Terravision:** Budget coach - £9-12, 75 min
- **Taxi:** £90-120 to central London

Luton Airport (LTN) - Budget Airlines

- **Location:** 56 km north of London (60-90 minutes)
- **Train:** Shuttle bus to Luton Airport Parkway, then train to St Pancras - £17-20 total, 45-60 min
- **National Express:** Coach to Victoria - £11-15, 75-90 min
- **Taxi:** £80-110 to central London

City Airport (LCY) - Business Travelers

- **Location:** 11 km east, in Docklands (20-40 minutes)
- **DLR (Docklands Light Railway):** To Bank/Canary Wharf - £5.60, 20-30 min
- **Elizabeth Line:** Connect from Custom House - £5.60, 25-35 min to central London
- **Taxi:** £30-50 to central London

London Underground (The Tube)

System Overview

- **Lines:** 11 color-coded lines (Central, Circle, Piccadilly, etc.)
- **Stations:** 270 stations across Greater London
- **Hours:** ~5:00am-midnight (Night Tube on some lines Friday/Saturday)
- **Frequency:** Every 2-5 minutes peak hours, 5-10 minutes off-peak

Oyster Card & Contactless (Essential!)

Oyster Card: - Reloadable smart card (£7 refundable deposit) - Top-up at machines or online - Daily/weekly caps (best value) - Buy at any station

Contactless Payment (Credit/Debit Card): - Tap credit/debit card or phone directly at gates - Same pricing as Oyster - Automatic daily/weekly capping - No need to buy separate card -

Recommended for tourists (simplest)

Zones and Fares

Zone System: - Zone 1: Central London (most attractions) - Zones 2-6: Outer London, suburbs - Heathrow in Zone 6

Peak vs Off-Peak: - **Peak:** Mon-Fri 6:30-9:30am and 4:00-7:00pm - **Off-Peak:** All other times, weekends, holidays - Peak fares ~30-50% higher

Sample Fares (Contactless/Oyster): - Zone 1 only: £2.80 (off-peak), £3.40 (peak) - Zone 1-2: £2.80 (off-peak), £3.40 (peak) - Zone 1-6 (Heathrow): £5.60 (off-peak), £6.70 (peak)

Daily Caps: - Zones 1-2: £8.50 per day maximum - Zones 1-6: £15.20 per day maximum - **Unlimited travel after hitting cap**

Navigation Tips

- **Maps:** Iconic tube map (grab at station or use TfL app)
- **Direction:** Follow line color and check final destination
- **Transfers:** Many stations connect lines, follow signs
- **Escalator Etiquette:** Stand on RIGHT, walk on LEFT (very important!)
- **Mind the Gap:** Watch gap between train and platform
- **Apps:** Citymapper (best), Google Maps, TfL Go (official)

Buses

- **Coverage:** Extensive, reaches areas tube doesn't
- **Fare:** £1.75 flat rate, pay with Oyster/contactless only (no cash)
- **Frequency:** 5-15 minutes most routes
- **24-Hour Routes:** Night buses (prefixed with N, e.g. N29)
- **Iconic:** Red double-decker buses (sit upstairs for views)
- **Free Transfers:** Unlimited bus/tram transfers within 1 hour

Black Cabs (Iconic London Taxis)

- **Knowledge:** Drivers complete "The Knowledge" (3-4 years memorizing 25,000 streets)
- **Hailing:** Raise hand when "TAXI" light lit (yellow light = available)
- **Fare:** Metered, starts ~£3.80, £2.80-3.80 per mile depending on time
- **Credit Cards:** All accept cards now
- **Tipping:** 10% or round up
- **Accessible:** Wheelchair accessible (legal requirement)

- **Expensive:** But reliable, expert drivers

Uber/Bolt

- **Availability:** Excellent coverage
- **Pricing:** Cheaper than black cabs usually (except surge)
- **Pickup:** Can be tricky in central London (find quiet street)
- **Note:** Congestion charge added if traveling in central London

Boris Bikes (Santander Cycles)

- **Stations:** 750+ docking stations
- **Cost:** £1.65 per 30-min ride (first ride free with annual membership)
- **Usage:** Unlock via app or at docking station kiosk
- **Safety:** Bike lanes improving but share road with cars (be cautious)
- **Helmets:** Not provided (bring your own or skip)

Walking

- **Central London:** Very walkable, compact distances
- **Thames Path:** Beautiful riverside walks
- **Parks:** Regent's Canal, Hampstead Heath, Richmond Park (walkable greenspaces)
- **Crossing:** Look RIGHT first (traffic drives on left!), crossings say "LOOK RIGHT"

Cultural Tips & Customs

The British Queue

- **Sacred:** Queuing is serious business, never cut
- **Formation:** Single orderly line, wait your turn
- **Punishment:** Cutting will get you publicly called out (social death)
- **Everywhere:** Bus stops, shops, pubs, attractions

Politeness and Manners

- **"Sorry":** British say sorry constantly (even when not at fault)
- **"Please" and "Thank you":** Essential, use liberally
- **Small Talk:** Weather is safe topic, avoid politics/money

- **Personal Space:** British value space, don't stand too close
- **Eye Contact:** Polite but not intense

Pub Etiquette

- **Order at Bar:** Don't sit and wait for service (traditional pubs)
- **Rounds:** Buy drinks for group, take turns
- **Last Orders:** Drink up when called (usually 15 min before close)
- **Crisps/Peanuts:** Classic pub snacks, perfectly acceptable
- **Making Friends:** Pubs are social, locals friendly after a pint

Reserved Nature

- **Understated:** British tend to be reserved, understated
- **Humor:** Dry, sarcastic, self-deprecating
- **Not Rude:** Reserved ≠ unfriendly, just takes time to warm up
- **Help:** Ask for directions/help, people usually happy to assist

Tea Culture

- **National Drink:** Tea is life (150 million cups per day in UK)
- **How to Make:** Milk in after tea (debate rages about milk first vs after)
- **Builder's Tea:** Strong black tea with milk and sugar (working-class staple)
- **"Fancy a cuppa?":** Invitation for tea and chat

British vs American English

- **Vocabulary Differences:**
 - Lift = Elevator
 - Loo = Bathroom
 - Queue = Line
 - Chips = Fries, Crisps = Chips
 - Trousers = Pants, Pants = Underwear
 - Torch = Flashlight
 - Cheers = Thank you/Goodbye/Cheers (multipurpose!)

Safety & Health

General Safety

- **Crime:** Relatively safe, standard urban awareness needed
- **Pickpockets:** Tourist areas (Oxford Street, Tube, markets), keep bags zipped
- **Night Safety:** Most central areas safe, use common sense, stick to lit areas
- **Scams:** Ticket touts (buy from official sources), fake charity collectors

Specific Safety Tips

- **Tube:** Watch belongings, phone snatching at doors before closing
- **Traffic:** Look RIGHT when crossing (drives on left!), marked "LOOK RIGHT" at crossings
- **Drinking:** Pace yourself, British pubs have strong pours
- **Neighborhoods:** Vast majority safe, avoid isolated areas late night

Emergency Services

- **Universal Emergency:** 999 or 112 (police, fire, ambulance)
- **Non-Emergency Police:** 101
- **NHS (Healthcare):** 111 for non-emergency medical advice

Healthcare

- **NHS:** National Health Service (free for UK residents)
- **Tourists:** Emergency care free, other treatment charged (expensive)
- **Travel Insurance:** Essential for international visitors
- **Pharmacies:** Boots, Superdrug (over-the-counter medications)
- **Emergency Rooms:** Called A&E (Accident & Emergency), long waits for non-urgent

Weather Preparedness

- **Rain:** Possible year-round, carry umbrella or rain jacket always
- **Layers:** Weather changeable, dress in layers
- **Summer:** Rarely very hot, but AC uncommon (prepare for hot tube)
- **Winter:** Cold and damp, waterproof coat essential

Practical Information

Electricity and Adapters

- **Voltage:** 230V
- **Frequency:** 50Hz
- **Plug Type:** Type G (three rectangular prongs)
- **Adapters:** US/EU visitors need adapters (buy at airport, Boots, or Amazon)
- **Note:** Switches on outlets (turn on to use)

Internet and WiFi

- **Public WiFi:** Most cafes, pubs, museums, Transport for London (on buses/some stations)
- **The Cloud:** Free WiFi network at many locations
- **SIM Cards:** Three, EE, Vodafone (tourist SIMs £10-30 for 7-30 days)
- **Coverage:** Excellent 4G/5G, even on tube platforms (not in tunnels)

Money and Currency

- **Currency:** British Pound Sterling (£)
- **Notes:** £5, £10, £20, £50 (£50 often refused at small shops)
- **Coins:** 1p, 2p, 5p, 10p, 20p, 50p, £1, £2
- **Cashless:** Very card-friendly, contactless everywhere
- **ATMs:** Abundant, most free (avoid "convenience" ATMs charging fees)
- **Exchange:** Avoid airport, use ATMs or Post Office for best rates

VAT (Value Added Tax)

- **Rate:** 20% on most goods and services
- **Included:** Prices include VAT (what you see is what you pay)
- **Tourist Refund:** Claim VAT refund for purchases over £100 (shop must offer Tax Free Shopping)

Business Hours

- **Shops:** 9:00/10:00-18:00/19:00 Mon-Sat, 11:00-17:00 Sun (shorter hours)
- **Supermarkets:** Many 24-hour or 7am-11pm
- **Pubs:** ~11:00-23:00 (midnight Fri/Sat)

- **Restaurants:** Lunch 12:00-15:00, Dinner 18:00-22:00 (many all-day)
- **Museums:** Usually 10:00-17:00/18:00, some closed Mondays
- **Sunday Trading:** Large shops limited to 6 hours on Sundays

Useful Apps

- **Citymapper:** Best transport app for London (essential)
- **TfL Go:** Official Transport for London app
- **Uber:** Rideshare and Uber Eats
- **Deliveroo/Just Eat:** Food delivery
- **OpenTable:** Restaurant reservations

Public Holidays

- **New Year's Day:** January 1
- **Good Friday:** March/April (variable)
- **Easter Monday:** March/April (variable)
- **Early May Bank Holiday:** First Monday in May
- **Spring Bank Holiday:** Last Monday in May
- **Summer Bank Holiday:** Last Monday in August
- **Christmas Day:** December 25
- **Boxing Day:** December 26

Note: Most shops closed Christmas Day, reduced service Boxing Day and bank holidays.

Day Trips from London

Oxford

- **Distance:** 90 km northwest (1 hour by train)
- **Highlights:** University colleges, Bodleian Library, Christ Church (Harry Potter filming location)
- **Transport:** Train from Paddington (£10-30 return)
- **Duration:** Half day or full day

Cambridge

- **Distance:** 80 km north (1 hour by train)
- **Highlights:** University colleges, King's College Chapel, punting on River Cam

- **Transport:** Train from King's Cross (£12-35 return)
- **Duration:** Full day

Brighton

- **Distance:** 85 km south (1 hour by train)
- **Highlights:** Beach, Brighton Pier, Royal Pavilion, bohemian vibe
- **Transport:** Train from Victoria or London Bridge (£12-35 return)
- **Duration:** Full day

Stonehenge

- **Distance:** 140 km southwest (2-3 hours by tour)
- **Highlights:** Neolithic stone circle (UNESCO)
- **Transport:** Train to Salisbury + tour, or day tour from London
- **Duration:** Full day (often combined with Bath)

Bath

- **Distance:** 190 km west (1.5 hours by train)
- **Highlights:** Roman Baths, Georgian architecture, Jane Austen sites
- **Transport:** Train from Paddington (£25-60 return)
- **Duration:** Full day

Windsor Castle

- **Distance:** 35 km west (30-50 min by train)
- **Highlights:** Royal residence, State Apartments, St. George's Chapel
- **Transport:** Train from Waterloo or Paddington (£10-15 return)
- **Duration:** Half day

Budget Guide

Daily Budget Estimates

Budget Traveler (£60-100/day): - Accommodation: Hostel dorm (£25-45) - Meals: Supermarket breakfast, pub lunch, street food dinner (£20-30) - Transport: Oyster card (£8-10 daily cap) - Activities: Free museums, one paid attraction (£10-15)

Mid-Range Traveler (£150-250/day): - Accommodation: Budget hotel/Airbnb (£80-120) - Meals: Cafe breakfast, pub lunch, restaurant dinner (£40-60) - Transport: Oyster + occasional taxi (£15-20) - Activities: Paid attractions, theater, tours (£30-50)

Luxury Traveler (£400+/day): - Accommodation: 4-5 star hotel (£250-500+) - Meals: Restaurant dining, afternoon tea, fine dining (£100-200+) - Transport: Taxis/Uber (£30-50) - Activities: West End theater, private tours, exclusive experiences (£80-150+)

Money-Saving Tips

1. **Free Museums:** British Museum, National Gallery, Tate Modern, Natural History (all free!)
2. **Oyster/Contactless:** Daily cap much cheaper than individual tickets
3. **Lunch Specials:** Many restaurants offer lunch prix fixe (cheaper than dinner)
4. **Markets:** Borough, Camden for cheap meals
5. **Supermarkets:** Tesco, Sainsbury's for cheap breakfast/lunch (£3-5 meal deals)
6. **TKTS Booth:** Discount West End theater tickets (Leicester Square)
7. **Walking:** Central London walkable, save transport fares
8. **Free Walking Tours:** Tip-based tours (pay what you think it's worth)

Final Tips

1. **Mind the Gap:** Between train and platform (you'll hear this constantly)
2. **Stand on the Right:** Escalators - stand right, walk left (!)
3. **Carry Umbrella:** London weather unpredictable
4. **Download Citymapper:** Essential for navigation
5. **Free Museums:** Most major museums free (donations appreciated)
6. **Pub Culture:** Order at bar, buy rounds, embrace "last orders"
7. **Queue Properly:** Never cut, British will judge you
8. **Look RIGHT:** When crossing (traffic drives on left)
9. **Contactless Everything:** Tap card/phone everywhere (Tube, buses, shops)
10. **Don't Rush:** Embrace British pace, enjoy pub conversations, savor tea

Emergency Contacts: - Emergency: 999 or 112 - Non-Emergency Police: 101 - NHS Non-Emergency: 111

London is a city of contrasts - royal palaces and punk rock, traditional pubs and cutting-edge cuisine, ancient history and modern innovation. Respect the queue, mind the gap, and embrace the dry humor.

Enjoy your London adventure! Cheers!